After Everyone Agrees

7 questions to turn agreement into action

When I work with leadership teams, I look beyond agreement in the room. A decision can sound settled while each person leaves with a different understanding of what happens next. Before asking for more commitment, I help the team check what was decided, who can act and what must give way.

Christian Lefevre · Managing Partner

THE FIRST MOVE

Make the commitment specific before you leave.

Seven questions before you leave

01 What have we actually decided?
State the choice made, including what remains open.

02 Would each of us describe it the same way?
Ask people to restate the decision in their own words.

03 Who is accountable for moving it forward?
Name one owner with the authority to act.

04 What will we stop or postpone to make room?
Identify the work that must give way to this commitment.

05 Whose cooperation have we assumed?
Confirm commitments from people outside this room.

06 What concern has not yet been said aloud?
Surface the concern people may hesitate to raise.

07 What evidence will we review, and when?
Agree a visible next step and a date to check progress.

Avoid three traps

- **Treating silence as consent**
  A quiet room may conceal doubts or a different reading of the decision.
- **Assigning work to "the team"**
  Shared responsibility can leave everyone waiting for someone else.
- **Adding without subtracting**
  A new priority competes with work already promised.

Check the agreement

10 MINUTES / ONE DECISION

Ask each person to write:

- **What we decided**
- **What I will do next**
- **What I need from others**

Compare answers before discussing them. Resolve the differences, then record the owner, first action and review date.

IN PRACTICE One team, two ways of working

Consider the first joint leadership meeting of two merging biopharmas. The executives agree to work as "one team". When they discuss a delayed project, one group expects the project leader to decide; the other expects a leadership committee review. Both assumed "one team" meant extending their own way of working. They pause to agree which decisions will sit with project leaders, which need collective review and what each company's approach can contribute.

FINAL THOUGHT

I would rather hear a difficult objection in the room than discover it later through inaction.

NEXT NOTE When Everything Is a Priority